Toronto Metropolitan University

Metropolitan Undergraduate Engineering Society

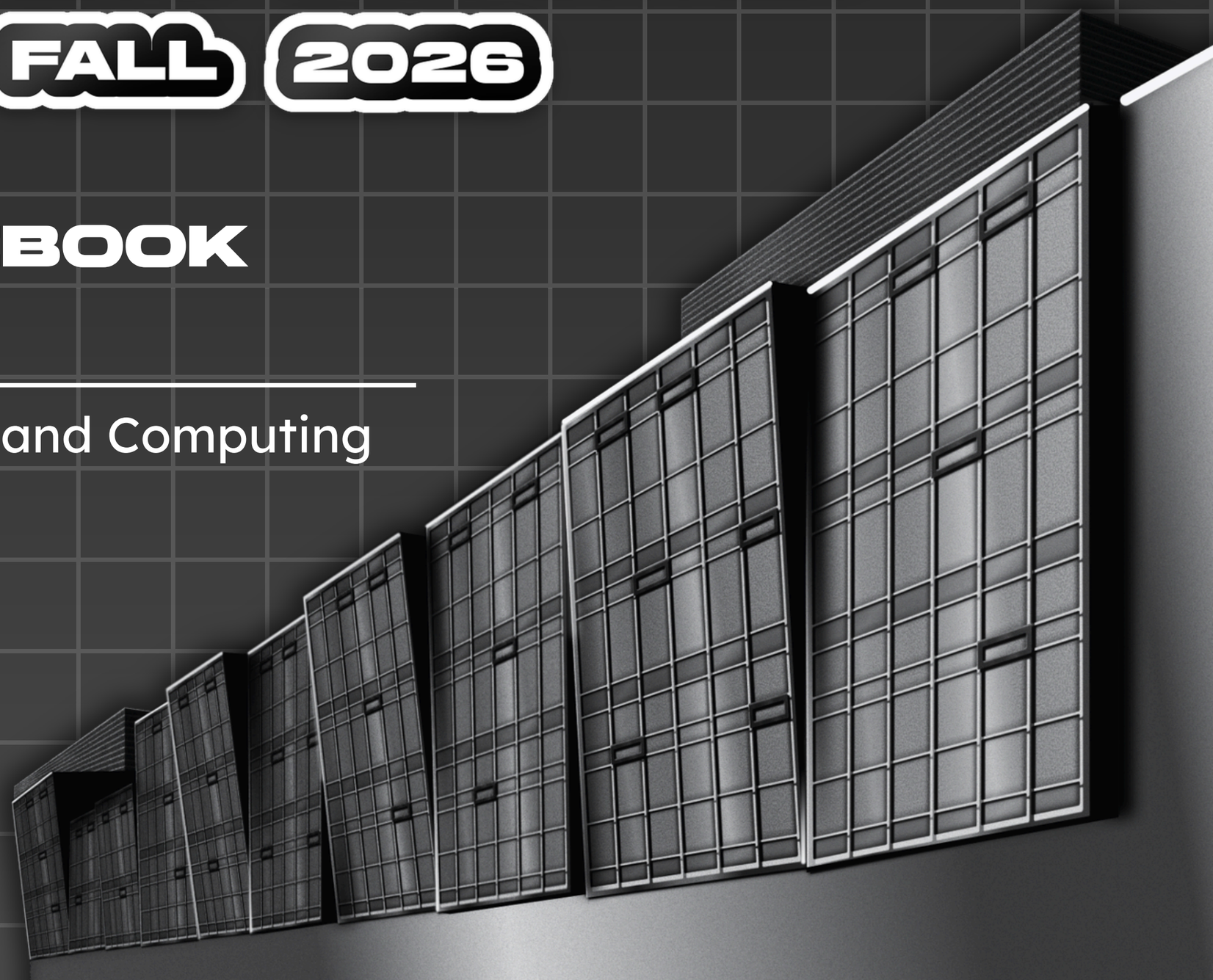
TORONTO METROPOLITAN UNIVERSITY ENGINEERING COMPETITION

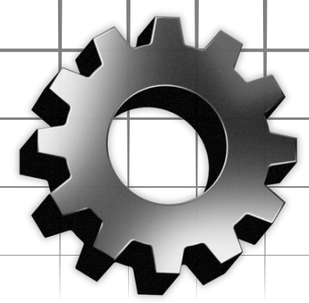
FALL 2026

DEBATE RULEBOOK

NOVEMBER 7 & 8, 2026

George Vari Engineering and Computing Centre





1.1 GOAL

Parliamentary Debate Competitors must use analytical techniques to present, with minimum preparation, a reasoned point of view of a resolution that has not been disclosed beforehand. The goal is to assess the competitors' abilities to convey ideas and develop arguments. The purpose is not to assess competitors' knowledge of parliamentary procedure and formal debating rules. Therefore, the rules normally used in debates have been modified and relaxed to enable students with no formal debate experience to take part. The debate will be conducted in a shortened Canadian National Style debate format.

1.2 TEAM COMPOSITION

The team must consist of two (2) members.

1.3 LANGUAGE

A team may choose to debate in either English or French. Both members from the same team must debate in the same language for the entire round.

1.4 RESOURCES

1.4.1. Facilities Required

- Two (2) amphitheaters
- Two (2) rooms for judge's deliberation
- Rooms for debater's preparation

1.4.2. Personnel Required

1.4.2.1. Judges

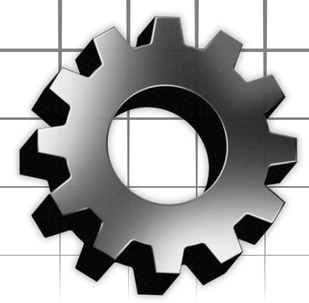
A minimum of three (3) judges (in any excess, an odd number of judges) per room are required to assess the problem-solving abilities, proposed solution, communication skills and team dynamics of each competitor. Judges must come from a variety of backgrounds. In addition, it is not necessary for judges to have technical experience related to the topic, but it is suggested that judges have knowledge and/or experience in debating.

1.4.2.2. Competition Lead

The debate coordinator and the VP Competition(s) are responsible for the entire implementation of the Debate competition. The competition coordinator must develop debate topics and schedule and organize the overall competition procedure. It is recommended that the Competition Coordinator have previous experience organizing, judging, or participating in formal debates.

1.4.2.3 Debate Mediator/Debate Chair

The Debate Mediator, otherwise known as a Debate Chair, is the expert in debate procedure and interpretation. The Mediator acts as an impartial judge and ensures that the judges understand the rules of the debate.



The Chair of the debate ensures the rules of the debate are upheld. They must grant the rights to speak (introduces the debater) and enforces the time limits. Most importantly, the Chair makes rulings on the “points of procedure” put forward by the debaters. The decisions of the chair are final.

1.4.2.4 Timekeeper

The Timekeeper is responsible for ensuring that competitors stay within their allotted time limits. The timekeeper will inform speakers of specific time intervals. The Timekeeper will use hand signals to indicate the number of minutes a speaker has left to conclude their argument.

The Timekeeper will indicate when Points of Information (POIs) become permitted and when they are no longer permitted. POIs are not permitted during the first or last thirty (30) seconds of a constructive speech or during rebuttal speeches. The Timekeeper will also provide a visible ten (10) second countdown near the end of each speech. A fifteen (15) second grace period will be permitted after the official speaking time expires, after which the Chair will stop the speaker.

1.4.3 Equipment Provided by MEC

The Competition Organizers will provide an appropriate debate room, seating arrangements, a method of displaying the debate motion, and official timekeeping equipment.

Additional equipment, including microphones, projectors, or presentation displays, may be provided depending on the assigned room and competition requirements.

The Debate Chair will explain the room arrangement and preparation procedures before each debate.

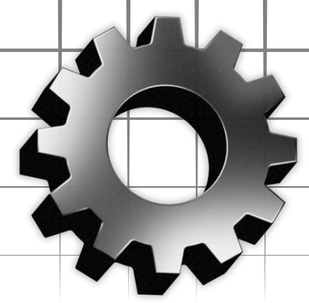
1.4.4 Allowed External Resources

Competitors may use paper, pens, and personal notes during preparation and debate. Electronic devices, internet access, and generative AI tools may only be used if expressly authorized by the Competition Coordinators. Props and other external materials are prohibited unless approved by the Competition Coordinators.

1.5 DEBATING RULES AND ELEMENTS

1.5.1. Teams

The debate is between two teams, each with two members. The government will be given the task of presenting an initial set of ideas and arguing their validity. The opposition will then proceed to show how these ideas are undesirable. During the Round Robin stage, Government and Opposition positions will be assigned in advance by the Competition Organizers to ensure that each team receives one Government position and one Opposition position across its two scheduled debates.



For the Semifinals, Third-Place Final, and Championship Final, a coin toss will determine which team receives the first choice of Government or Opposition position.

All assignments will be communicated to the participating teams before the relevant debate begins.

Teams are always expected to act responsibly. Inappropriate language or offensiveness towards the other team, the officials, or the audience is not acceptable. Teams are expected to direct all their speeches towards the Chair.

1.5.2. Resolutions

The resolutions will be assigned by the organizing committee and will be validated by the Debate Chairs before the competition begins. They will be related to an issue that the average engineering student should have a defensible opinion on without any preparation. The resolutions will not be truisms. Absolute words such as "all," "everyone," and "always" will also be avoided (e.g. "Be it resolved that all engineers are good at math" is not a good resolution, since there are always exceptions). Once both teams are informed of the resolution, they are given five (5) minutes to prepare for the debate.

1.5.3. Time Allotted to Debaters

The speaking order and times will be as follows:

- First speaker of the government: five (5) minutes
- First speaker of the opposition: five (5) minutes
- Second speaker of government: five (5) minutes
- Second speaker of the opposition: five (5) minutes
- Rebuttal by the first speaker of the opposition: two (2) minutes
- Rebuttal by the first speaker of the government: two (2) minutes

Each debate will consist of twenty-four (24) minutes of scheduled speaking time, excluding the ten (10) minute preparation period, permitted pauses, and any authorized grace periods.

If a debater is over the time limit, the Chair will allow a fifteen (15) second grace period. Upon the exhaustion of the speaking time, loud pounding on tables will be deemed appropriate.

1.5.4. Types of Motions

The motions that competitors may encounter will be of the following types:

Abbreviation	Meaning
THW	This House Would
THBT	This House Believes That
THS	This House Supports
THO	This House Opposes
THP	This House Prefers
THR	This House Regrets

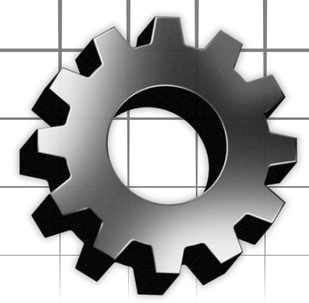
1.5.4.1 The Principle Case (This House Believes That)

In a principle case, the government presents a principle and a contention. The principle is a general statement that is debatable based on facts, experience, or morals. Examples include "Engineers need to be well rounded" and "Canadians abuse the free health-care system." The contention is the application of the principle to a situation relating to the resolution. The contention must be about one major topic and may be a restatement of the resolution. Example contentions for the above principles would be "Engineering students should be required to take more complementary studies classes" and "People should be discouraged from going to a doctor unless necessary."

1.5.4.2 The Plan Case (This House Would)

In a plan case, the government still identifies a principle and a contention. Once this is done, they present a plan for implementing the contention and changing the status quo. They must identify the need for change and how the plan will induce this change. Example plans for the above contentions would be “Students should be required to take two years of general studies before entering an engineering program” and “Individuals should be charged a fee every time they visit a doctor.”

The plan case is the most effective when the principle and contention are almost non-debatable. For example, if the resolution is “Be it resolved that waste management should become more stringent,” the contention is almost unquestionable. However, the proposition can intensify the debate by adding, “Thus, we propose that any household that produces more than a certain quota



of waste be severely fined.” In a plan case, it is important that the plan does not become too specific since preparation time is limited and the technical knowledge necessary to develop the plan is non-existent.

1.5.5. Role of Government

The government must narrow down the resolution so that the debate will be about one major topic. The resolutions must not be squirreled or converted into truisms. Squirreling is the act of redefining the resolution so that it has a meaning different than the one intended by the resolution. The government must also avoid specific knowledge debates where the average engineer has no familiarity with the topic. The government can follow one of two different strategies in the debate.

1.5.6. The First Speaker

The first speaker of the government must explain the interpretation of the resolution, clearly state the principle and contention, and clarify any definitions. If a plan case is introduced, the entire plan must be outlined in the first speaker's speech. Finally, the first speaker must initiate the argumentation for the contention and plan.

1.5.7. The Second Speaker

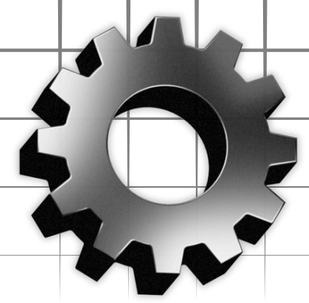
The second speaker of the government continues the argumentation of the first speaker and reaffirms concepts that have been attacked by the opposition. New parts of a plan may not be introduced and terms in the resolution may not be defined. New lines of argumentation and new evidence, however, may be introduced.

1.5.8. Role of Opposition

The opposition’s task is to convince the judges that the government’s views are fallacious. If the case presented by the government is a truism or requires specific knowledge to debate, the opposition can point this out in their first speech and will be rewarded accordingly by the judges. If the point is well taken, then the opposition must redefine the resolution in a debatable manner. If the government presents a principle case, the opposition is left with little more to do than attack the principle. If the government presents a plan case, the opposition can attack the principle, the contention or the arguments for the plan. The opposition can also show how the plan will not work or identify the undesirable side effects that it will create. Finally, the opposition may propose a counter plan that is more effective than the original plan. The first speaker of the opposition must introduce counter plans.

1.5.9. Rebuttals

In the rebuttals, the most prevalent elements of the debate must be summarized in a concise and convincing manner. During rebuttal speeches, competitors must summarize, challenge, and respond to arguments already presented in the debate. No new independent arguments or proposals may be



introduced during either rebuttal. New analysis directly responding to arguments already raised is permitted.

1.5.10. Questions (Points of Information)

Questions, also known as Points of Information or POIs, are a secondary means of refuting arguments. They can promptly point out deficiencies in ideas, put speakers on the spot and hog time. The debater who currently holds the floor has the authority to take or ignore questions. The opponent who wishes to ask a question indicates their desire by simply standing up and extending an arm forward. If the debater does not wish to take the question, he or she can indicate by a wave of the hand or a simple "no, thank you". If this occurs, the inquiring party must sit down. If the current debater wishes to entertain the question, it must be stated by the opponent in less than fifteen (15) seconds during which the speaker must yield the floor.

The debater who holds the floor, or their team member, may take part in answering the question. The time used to ask and answer the question comes out of the current debater's allotted time. Each debater must accept one question during his or her speech, if the opponent is making an honest attempt to ask questions. Three attempts at asking a question in one speech constitutes an honest attempt. Questions will not be allowed in the first or last thirty seconds of a speech, or during rebuttal speeches.

1.5.11. Heckling

Often, the speaker can contradict himself/herself or make an absurd assumption. Heckling at this time will point out the error and add to the debate. Competitors must remain respectful while another participant is speaking. Brief expressions of agreement or disagreement may be permitted at the Debate Chair's discretion, provided they do not interrupt or intimidate the speaker. Repeated disruptions, personal attacks, and offensive remarks are prohibited. If excess heckling becomes disturbing, the Chair may intervene.

1.5.12. Points of Procedure

If a team believes that one of the rules of the debate have been broken, they must immediately alert the Chair of the violation by standing and saying, "Point of Procedure." The Chair will then respond with, "Make your point." The team will then proceed to explain how the debate rules have not been followed. Finally, the Chair will rule on the point by saying, "Point well taken" or "Point not taken." If it is obvious that the Chair is incorrect, the team should not argue with the Chair, but expect the judges to compensate for the Chair’s shortcomings. The time it takes to rise and rule on a point is not included in the speaking time of the team currently debating. The following are violations that warrant a point of procedure:

- Unprofessional behavior
- Offensive behavior

- Misquotations
- Speaking to the opposition instead of the audience
- Presenting new arguments in the rebuttal
- Introduction of parts of a plan by the second speaker

If the government has presented a truism or specific knowledge case, the opposition must wait until the end of the first debater's speech to point this out. Moreover, if the officials have failed to follow the rules of debate (incorrect speaking order, too much speaking time allowed, etc.), it may be politely pointed out to them with a Point of Procedure. Points of Procedures are commonly seen to detract from a debate when offered incorrectly. Points of Procedure which take away from the flow of a debate unnecessarily will be penalized by the judges.

1.6 PROCEDURE/TIMELINE

1.6.1. Pre-Competition

Prior to the competition, the official debate rules and relevant competition information will be communicated to registered competitors through authorized MEC communication channels.

1.6.2. Presentation Order

The debate schedule will be prepared at random and presented at the pre-competition briefing (at least thirty (30) minutes prior to the first debate). This schedule will remain visible and updated systematically throughout the competition. The schedule should also illustrate the path which a team will follow depending on wins and losses.

1.6.3. Tournament Format

The Debate Competition will consist of a Round Robin stage, followed by Semifinals, a Third-Place Final, and a Championship Final.

During the Round Robin stage, teams will compete in scheduled debates. Results from this stage will determine which teams advance to the Semifinals.

The four highest-ranked teams will advance to the Semifinals. The winners of the Semifinals will compete in the Championship Final to determine first and second place. The losing Semifinal teams will compete in the Third-Place Final to determine third place.

The Competition Organizers will communicate the Round Robin schedule, advancement criteria, and any applicable tiebreaking procedures before the tournament begins.

Round Robin standings will be determined using the following criteria, in order:

1. Total number of debate wins.
2. Total combined judges' scores earned across the Round Robin stage.
3. Head-to-head result, where the tied teams competed against one another.
4. A predetermined final tiebreaking procedure administered by the Competition Organizers.

The four highest-ranked teams will advance to the Semifinals.

All ranking criteria and tiebreaking procedures must be communicated to competitors before the Round Robin stage begins.

The Competition Organizers will make reasonable efforts to provide rest periods between debates and ensure that all teams are treated fairly.

1.7 ASSESSMENT AND JUDGING

1.7.1. Judging

Each debate will be evaluated using the official MEC Debate Competition Scorecard. Judges will assess argument development, refutation, delivery, and teamwork using the criteria and point allocations provided in the scorecard.

Each judge will independently score both teams. The team with the higher combined score across the judging panel, after applicable deductions, will be declared the winner of the debate.

In the event of a tied combined score, the judging panel will determine the winner through a majority decision. The Debate Chair will record and announce the official result.

1.7.2. Feedback

Feedback forms shall be provided to each team following the announcement of winners but prior to the end of MEC.

1.8 KEY POINTS TO REVIEW

- Late teams will lose their opportunity to debate.
- Teams will have five (5) minutes to prepare for their debate.
- Debaters must always direct their speech to the audience and not the opposing team. They will be warned for their first offence and deducted points for subsequent infractions.

Judging Matrix:

Criteria	5 Points - Excellent	4 Points - Good	3 Points - Satisfactory	2 Points - Needs Improvement	1 Point - Poor	Total Points
Argument Development & Analysis	Arguments are exceptionally clear, logical, well-structured, and supported by strong reasoning and relevant evidence. Demonstrates an excellent understanding of the motion.	Arguments are clear, organized, and supported by relevant reasoning and evidence. Demonstrates a strong understanding of the motion.	Arguments are generally understandable and relevant but lack depth, consistency, or sufficient supporting evidence.	Arguments are weakly structured, insufficiently supported, or only partially relevant to the motion.	Arguments lack clear reasoning, supporting evidence, or an adequate understanding of the motion.	/5
Refutation & Responsiveness	Consistently identifies and effectively challenges opposing arguments using strong counter-analysis. Responds confidently to rebuttals and POIs.	Effectively addresses most opposing arguments with relevant counter-analysis and appropriate responses to POIs.	Addresses some opposing arguments but provides limited counter-analysis or inconsistent responses to POIs.	Refutations are weak, incomplete, or fail to address important opposing arguments.	Fails to meaningfully respond to opposing arguments or provide relevant counter-analysis.	/5
Delivery & Persuasiveness	Speaks clearly and confidently with excellent articulation, pacing, composure, and persuasive techniques. Maintains professionalism throughout.	Communicates clearly with good pacing, confidence, and persuasive delivery. Maintains appropriate professionalism.	Delivery is understandable but lacks consistency in pacing, confidence, or persuasiveness.	Delivery is difficult to follow at times, with limited confidence, engagement, or persuasive impact.	Delivery is consistently unclear, disorganized, or ineffective in communicating arguments.	/5
Team Coordination	Both speakers contribute meaningfully, support each other's arguments, and maintain a highly consistent and coordinated team position.	Both speakers contribute effectively and demonstrate good coordination and consistency.	Both speakers participate, but coordination or consistency between arguments is occasionally weak.	Participation is uneven, and speakers demonstrate limited coordination or inconsistent arguments.	Little evidence of teamwork, with significant inconsistencies or minimal contribution from one speaker.	/5
TOTAL						/20
Criteria	5 Points - Excellent	4 Points - Good	3 Points - Satisfactory	2 Points - Needs Improvement	1 Point - Poor	Total Points
Total Points:						

Comments	

Penalties:

Violation	First Offense	Repeated Offense
Unprofessional/Offensive behavior	A penalty of -1 to total score for team on each Judging matrix	An additional penalty of -1 to total score for each repeated offense
Misquotations	Misquoted point of argument will be struck from record	Misquoted point of argument will be struck from record
Speaking to opposition instead of the audience	A warning from the debate moderator	A penalty of -0.5 to total score for team on each judging matrix for each repeated offense
Presenting new arguments in the rebuttal	New argument will be struck from record and not allowed to be used further	New argument will be struck from record and not slowed to be used further
Introduction of parts of a plan by the second speaker	Part of plan will be struck from record and not allowed to be used further	Part of plan will be struck from record and not allowed to be used further